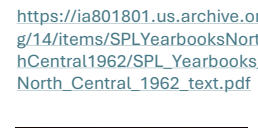
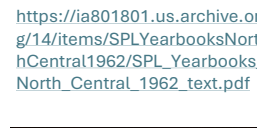
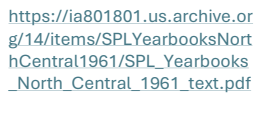
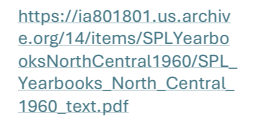
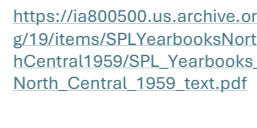
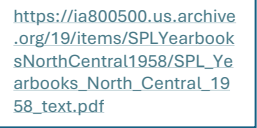


The Teacher Game for the North Central High School Bicentennial Class of 1976

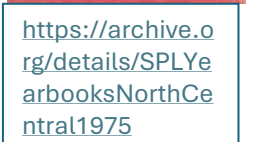
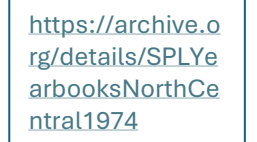
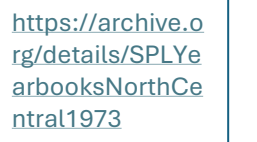
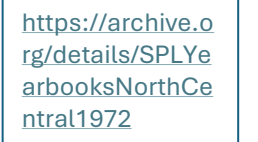
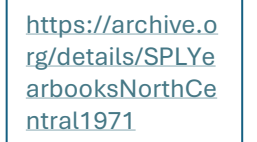
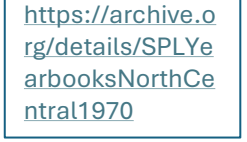
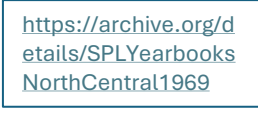
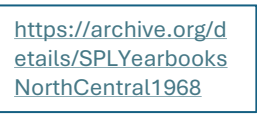
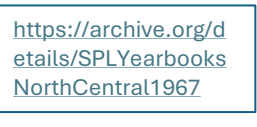
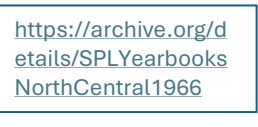
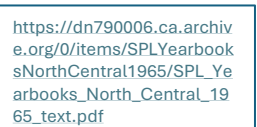
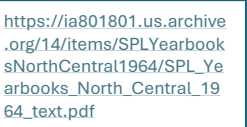
Bill Worstell

June 3, 2026

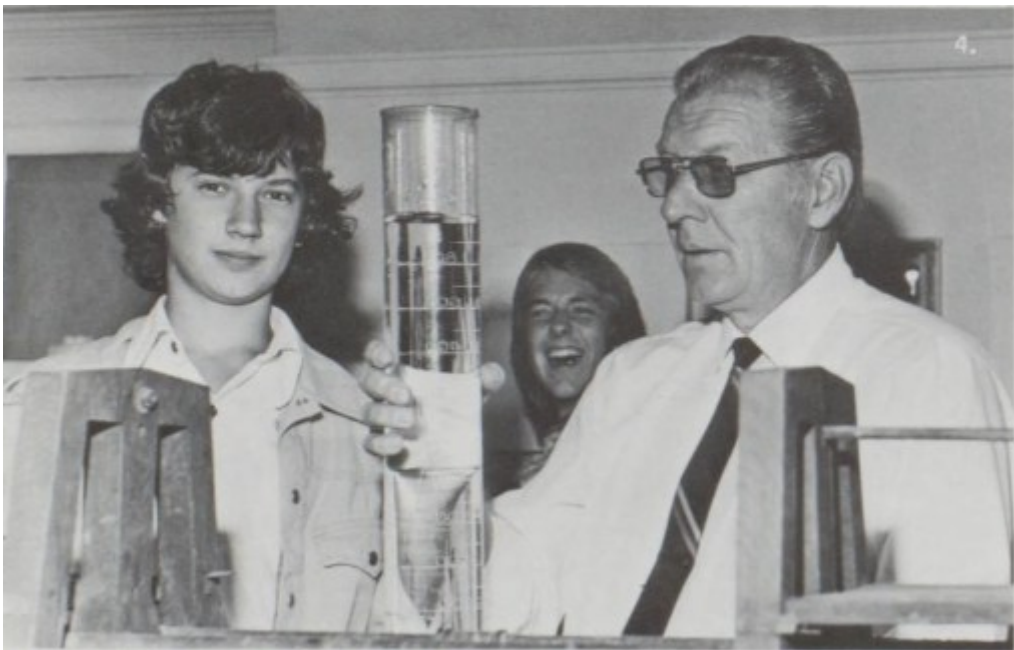


tamarack

1976



Which of our Teachers was a
member of North Central's
Class of 1947?



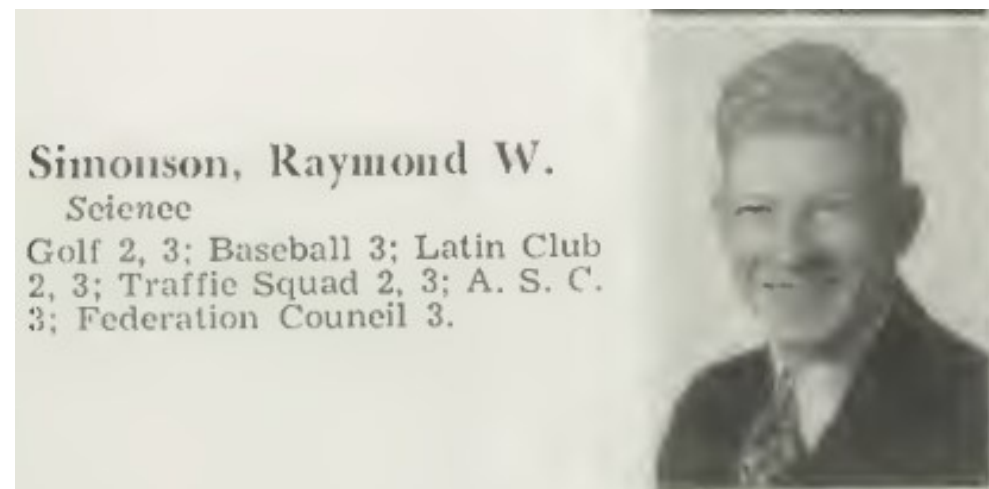
I found **yearbook and educational traces**, but **not a clean public obituary** for the North Central teacher Raymond Simonson in this pass. The public record trail is still useful. The strongest identification is that **Raymond Simonson was himself a North Central student before returning as a teacher**. The 1947 *Tamarack* lists **Raymond Simonson** among the January class students, and the 1952 Washington State College *Chinook* lists **Raymond Simonson, General, Spokane**, which fits a North Central graduate who later returned to Spokane Public Schools. ***For all I can find, he could be a near-centenarian and with us still.***

By **1954**, he was on the North Central faculty. In later yearbooks he is identified more specifically with **biology**, and sometimes **chemistry**: the 1956 *Tamarack* lists him in Science as **biology**; the 1958 *Tamarack* lists **Raymond Simonson, biology**; and the 1959 *Tamarack* lists **Raymond Simonson, chemistry**.

Age 18 in 1947, so born in 1929

He also had a substantial role in **boys' golf**. The 1959 *Tamarack* reports that a team coached by **Raymond Simonson** won the Lewiston Invitational Golf Tournament. The 1963 *Tamarack* says the varsity golf team, coached by Raymond Simonson, placed second in the fall All-City high-school tournament. In 1964 and 1965, he is listed with **Biology / Boys' Golf**, and in 1965 he is also listed with **Biology, Chemistry**.

He was still present in the 1970s. The 1972 *Tamarack* includes **Raymond Simonson** in a science/biology context, and 1976 evidence is consistent with a career continuing at least that long.



The evolution of **North Central High School (NC)** mirrors the transformation of American public education, shifting from an elite, classical academy into a modern, comprehensive institution. As you prepare to celebrate the landmark **50th anniversary of the Class of 1976**, looking back reveals how the school adapted across four distinct eras.

1908: The Era of Classical Academies and Civic Pride

When North Central opened its doors in September 1908, it stepped into a national educational landscape heavily influenced by the **1893 Committee of Ten report**, which standardized high school as a rigid, academic preparation ground for college. High school was still considered optional, and Spokane was experiencing a massive population boom fueled by the railroads and mining.

- The Educational Philosophy:** High school was meant to refine the mind through a strict, classical curriculum. Rote memorization, public speaking, and mental discipline were paramount.

- The Environment:** NC opened with just 12 classrooms in a magnificent structure that was a testament to civic pride. The academic atmosphere was elite and formal, emphasizing Latin, Greek, classical literature, rhetoric, and advanced mathematics. Early milestone events included visits from monumental historical figures like **William Jennings Bryan** and **Booker T. Washington**, highlighting the school's focus on oratory and civic responsibility.



A group of cheerleaders from North Central High School huddle under umbrellas in the fall of 1943. Photo courtesy of North Central High School (Photo courtesy of North Central High School / The Spokesman-Review)

<https://www.spokesman.com/stories/2026/mar/02/then-and-now-early-spokane-schools/>

[https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/North_Central_High_School_\(Spokane,_Washington\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/North_Central_High_School_(Spokane,_Washington))

<https://www.spokesman.com/stories/2008/jun/05/nc-marks-centennial/>



South Central was first: “We see your colors flying high, it’s Halloween!”

Spokane: Early Education

By **Stephen B. Emerson** | Posted 8/08/2008 | HistoryLink.org Essay 8723

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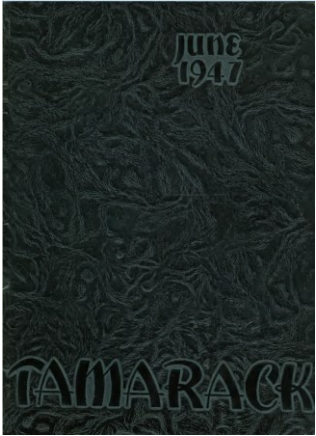
<https://www.historylink.org/file/8723>



<https://www.spokesman.com/then-and-now/2022/jul/25/then-and-now-spokane-high-school/>

1947

Tamarack



What was NC like in 1947?

Simonson, Raymond W.

Science

Golf 2, 3; Baseball 3; Latin Club
2, 3; Traffic Squad 2, 3; A. S. C.
3; Federation Council 3.



Who was the Earliest of our
Teachers to Teach at NC?

John P. Rodkey served as the beloved principal of North Central High School in Spokane, Washington, from 1959 until 1979. Born in 1921, he passed away on May 16, 2012. Before his long career in education, he served as a radio operator in the Army Air Forces during WWII.

Life and Legacy:

- **Background:** Born on a farm in Colorado, his family relocated to Post Falls, Idaho, during the Great Depression.
- **Career:** He spent 20 years at the helm of North Central High School, bringing deep compassion, grace, and energy to the student body.
- **Personal Life:** He was married, raised three children, and was a dedicated member of his church who valued faith, learning, and storytelling.

You can read more about his remarkable life or pay tribute through the full [Obituary for John P. Rodkey](#) published by Heritage Funeral & Cremation, or explore his legacy feature in the [Spokesman-Review](#).

John graduated from Whitworth College with his BA degree in Recreational Leadership in 1947 and a BA in Psych / Soc / Education in 1948. He later received his Master's Degree in Administration in 1958. He remained a loyal and active alum of Whitworth University. After student teaching at North Central High, he was hired to teach there after his college years. He taught from 1948 - '57, then served as Vice Principal of Shadle Park for the two opening-years, '57-'59. He then came back to NC as principal from '59-79.



Principal John P. Rodkey

Principal John P. Rodkey Bears Many Responsibilities

John P. Rodkey, as principal of North Central, assumes many responsibilities. Before he comes to school, he makes arrangements for substitute teachers. After arriving at school, he consults with teachers about grading and other problems.

In the morning, Mr. Rodkey works with the deans and vice-principal on acute discipline cases and has orientation with cadet teachers assigned by the near-by teacher-training colleges. Lunch, if any at all, is usually taken shortly after noon.

In the afternoon, Mr. Rodkey attends meetings with other secondary principals of the school district and with the athletic board of control to discuss league schedules and problems. Every

Tuesday after school he conducts a faculty meeting for the in-service training of teachers. Mr. Rodkey also edits the daily bulletin of school news and when completing this, he often has a meeting at the Administration building to work on millage and bond levies or other school matters with the board and superintendent.

During his busy day, Mr. Rodkey answers numerous phone calls, writes volumes of correspondence regarding former students, discusses curriculum problems with department heads and makes plans for building improvements. In the evenings, he attends the athletic, music and drama events of the school and helps chaperone the school dances.

1963 Tamarack

Freedom Places Responsibility Upon the Individual

Some persons in this great land of ours, yes—and in this school of ours, are not very aware of the great responsibility that FREEDOM places upon the individual. If one considers what freedom really is, it becomes obvious that freedom means only that a person is free to do what he ought to do. He is also free to pay the penalty for wrong choices!

As we come to the end of another year it is good to think back on the past—and yet to look ahead to the future. First, may I thank you for the cooperation you have given the school this year. The courteous way you treat your friends, your teachers, and visitors to our building; your loyalty to your school; your participation in the activities of the school—these are the things that are REALLY important to you and to communities in which you will reside! We should never forget that the citizens of Spokane, through tax sources, provide educational opportunities for us that are unknown to most of the world. Where else does freedom abound? Where else does the individual have such free choice in determining his own future? "Where, oh where, but in America?"

Take time at the end of this year to say a word of appreciation—to parents, to friends, to teachers, to your community, to all who have given you assistance in developing yourself toward a worthwhile future.

To those who will not be returning to North Central next year we give our kindest regards and send our best wishes, especially to GRADUATES who will be finding their way into new experiences in life. May you retain fond memories of your years at North Central, and may that which you have learned assist you in attaining those positive goals you have established.

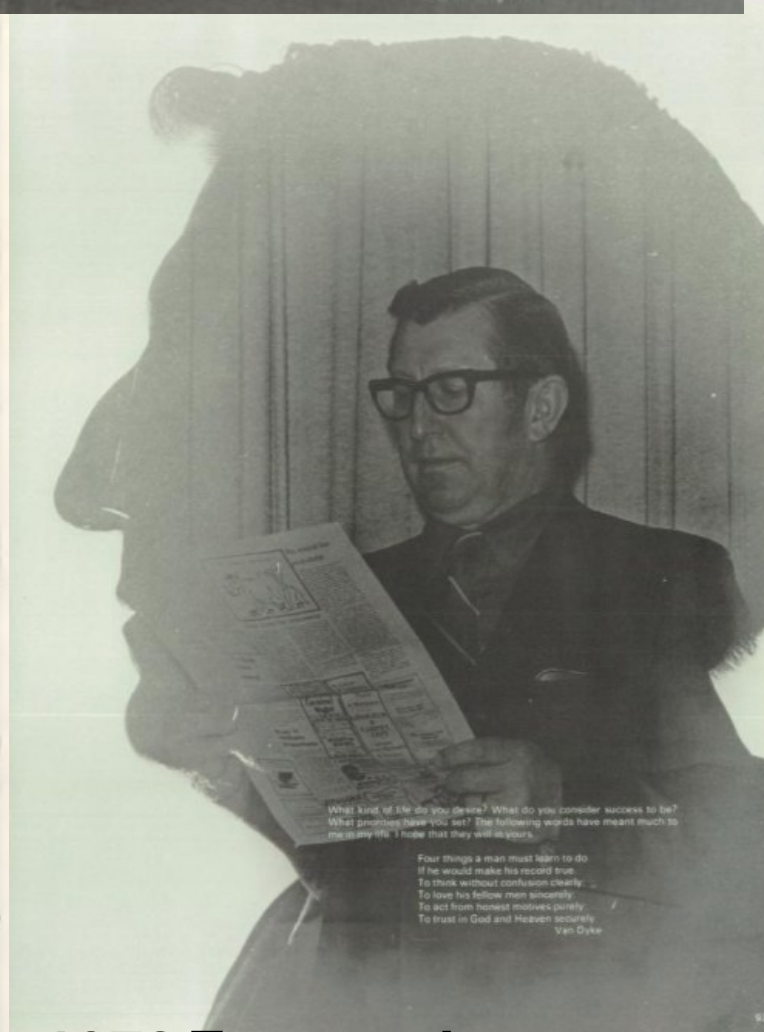
John P. Rodkey



Being a busy man, John P. Rodkey, Principal, scarcely takes time for photograph.

What kind of life do you desire? What do you consider success to be? What priorities have you set? The following words have meant much to me in my life. I hope that they will in yours.

Four things a man must learn to do
If he would make his record true.
To think without confusion clearly:
To love his fellow men sincerely:
To act from honest motives purely:
To trust in God and Heaven securely.
Van Dyke



What kind of life do you desire? What do you consider success to be? What priorities have you set? The following words have meant much to me in my life. I hope that they will in yours.

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To trust in God and Heaven securely.
Van Dyke

1973 Tamarack

1976 Tamarack

Impressions of North Central

John P. Rodkey, Principal

Who has seen the wind?

Neither I nor you,
But when the leaves hang trembling
The wind is passing through.

Who has seen the wind?

Neither you nor I,
But when the trees bow down their heads
The wind is passing by.

—Christina Rossetti

That poem has always held an awesome, mysterious, beauty to me, because it deals with something that is most intangible, yet very, very real. In many ways that is what North Central means to me. Who can precisely state what North Central really signifies? It is so real and so true to say that it was, and it is opportunity, joy, work, play, success, failure, sorrow, friendships. It is history and tradition; it is the cutting edge of tomorrow.

But whatever else North Central is, it is people caring, sharing, hoping, dreaming, remembering, helping, without reference to age, status, or gender. Yes, North Central was, and North Central is. We are all experiencing it.



My NC Institutional Lifetime Achievement Award

This goes to the Captain of our ship, Mr. Rodkey, here shown astride his majestic steed and approving the inaugural Rowdy Squad Regalia, and to his staff. In September, 1976 I was flying to Boston with a layover in Chicago when I discovered they had pinball machines there (that's me on the wall over there, with plenty of hair but no beard). Being skilled in the art and never tilting, I won a few bonus rounds, and missed my connecting flight. Mr. Rodkey, who had a brother in the Boston Area, had arranged for his brother to meet me at Boston Logan Airport and get me to Harvard Yard. When I did not arrive, he somehow tracked me down and got me there after dark to drop me off 1000 miles from anybody I knew. I think it was students like me who drove Mr. Rodkey to his tricycle, but he was ever up to the job.

Life lesson learned: Focus! And Priorities!

Technical lesson learned: If you absolutely must multi-task, keep a sharp eye on the clock.



Who was the Earliest of our
Teachers to have Consecutively
Taught at NC?

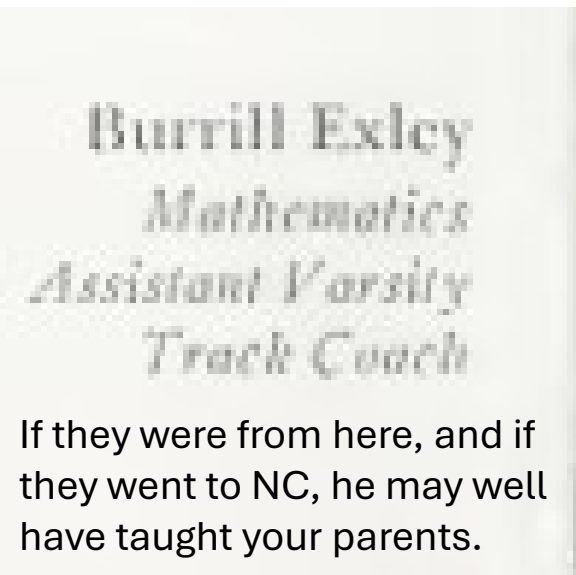


1954 Tamarack

It's the 1954 Tamarack, and we're down to just 2 finalists to see who, before we were all born, was the first of our teachers to start teaching at NC – both in the Math/Science Old Boy's Club! But wait, Mr. Rodkey was there as a teacher!

In an unexpected twist, the award for first one in the building goes to Mr. Simonson, who was a 1947 NC grad.

https://ia600607.us.archive.org/23/items/SPLYearbooksNorthCentral1947/SPL_Yearbooks_North_Central_1947_text.pdf



Burrill Exley
Mathematics
Assistant Varsity
Track Coach

If they were from here, and if they went to NC, he may well have taught your parents.



Mr. Simonson could later talk Latin with Mrs. Briscoe, I guess. But if you want to find out what the Traffic Squad was and the Federation Council did, you have to check out the 1947 Tamarack, which you can at the link above.

1947 Tamarack



John Rodkey
Social Studies
Senior Class Adviser

But then he went off to help found Shadle or something.



Raymond Simonson
Science
Detection Room

Did they put him in charge of the Detection Room because he already knew the place?

Simonson, Raymond W.
Science
Golf 2, 3; Baseball 3; Latin Club 2, 3; Traffic Squad 2, 3; A. S. C. 3; Federation Council 3.





It's the 1953 Tamarack, and ladies and gentlemen, we have a winner!

Mr. Exley was the first of our teachers to have taught at NC! And it's not even close – except for Mr. Rodkey, who is a special case, with a gap in his tenure.

He had in fact been teaching there for more than 25 years, since 1950. We have photographic evidence that he did not age a day his first 3 years.



1953 – age 30

Mr. Exley -

Burrill Dean Exley (1923–1997) was a beloved math teacher, coach, and department head at North Central High School in Spokane from 1950 to 1978.

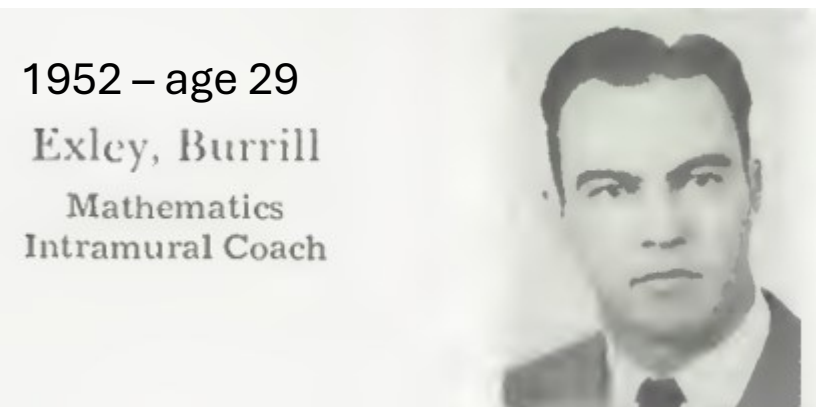
Biographical Highlights:

•Early Life &

Service: Born in Colville, Washington, he was a veteran of World War II.

•**Career:** He taught algebra and geometry at North Central High School for 28 years. Afterward, he taught at Kennedy High School in Burien, Washington, from 1980 to 1985.

1953 Tamarack



1952 – age 29
Exley, Burrill
Mathematics
Intramural Coach

1952 Tamarack

1951 Tamarack



Mr. Rodkey did not age for 2 years.

1949 Tamarack

1949 – age 28

JOHN RODKEY
English
Mathematics
Social Studies
Frosh Athletics



1950 Tamarack

John Rodkey
Social Studies
Whitworth College, B.A., B.Ed.





1976 Tamarack with Mr. Exley age 53

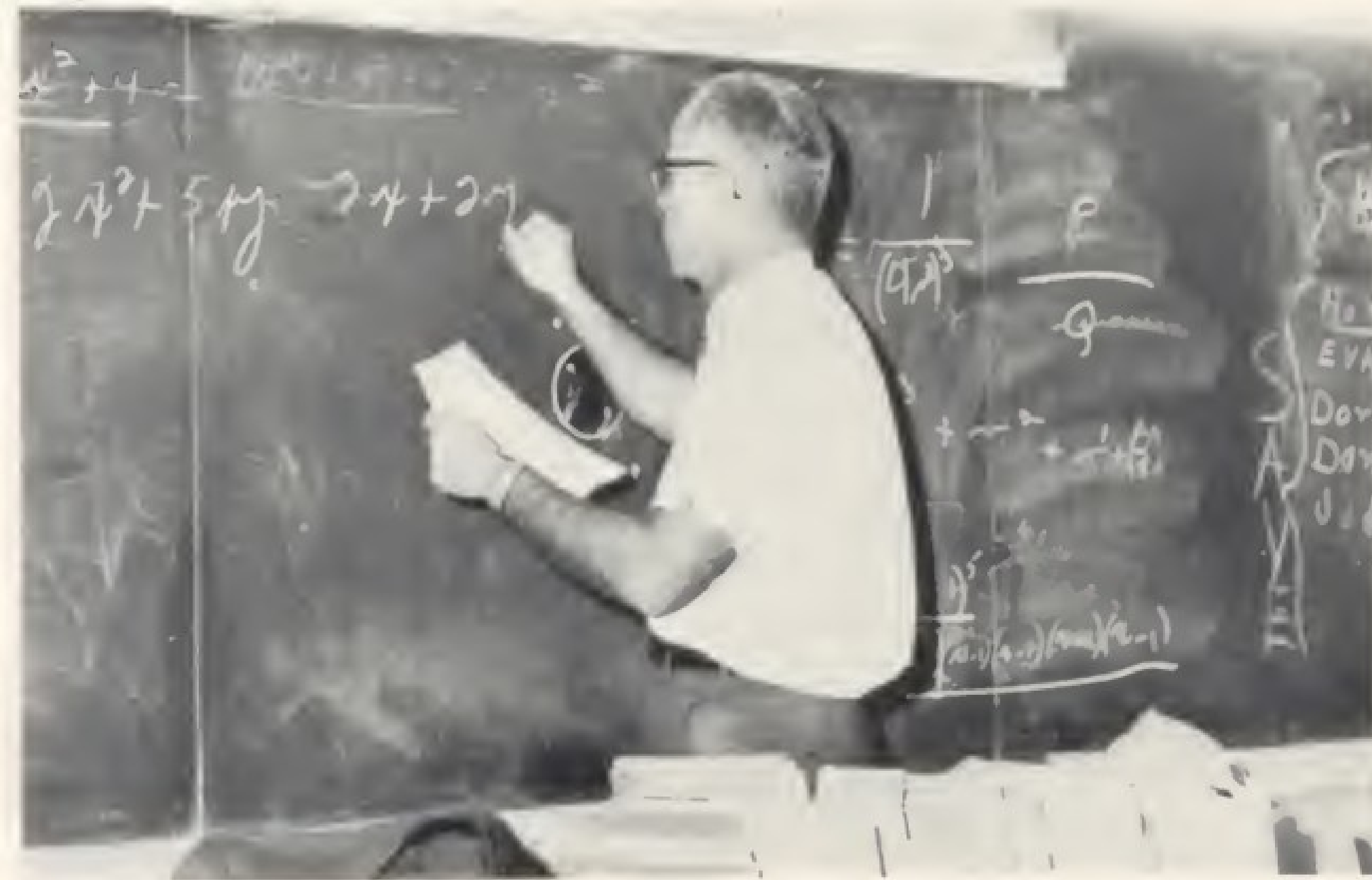
<https://www.spokesman.com/stories/1997/jun/27/obituaries/>

<https://www.spokesman.com/stories/2025/aug/25/this-day-in-history-gerald-ford-calls-new-kootenai/>

Burrill Dean Exley was born **May 8, 1923**, in or near **Colville, Washington**, and died **June 19, 1997**, at age **74**. His obituary appeared in *The Spokesman-Review* on June 27, 1997, under “Burrill Exley, Seattle.” It says no service was held at his request and that Bleitz Funeral Home in Seattle handled arrangements.

The obituary gives the key North Central facts very clearly: he was a **World War II veteran** and served as a **teacher, coach, and math department head at North Central High School from 1950 to 1978**. After leaving North Central, he taught at **Kennedy High School in Burien, Washington, from 1980 to 1985**. He was survived by his wife **Marion**, daughter **Linda Rumans**, and a granddaughter. A Washington State University record lists **Burrill Dean Exley** receiving a **Bachelor of Education** on **October 4, 1950**, which aligns neatly with his beginning at North Central that same year. The 1951 *Tamarack* faculty listing gives a fuller educational line: **Washington State College, B.A., B. of Ed.; Whitman College; Murray State Junior College; Dayton University**, and identifies him as a mathematics teacher, senior class adviser, and involved with intramural sports. The yearbooks also document his long role in the math department. The 1967 *Tamarack* lists **Burrill Exley — Mathematics, Department Head, Scholarship Committee**, and the 1969 *Tamarack* lists him as **Math Dept. Head**. Earlier yearbooks show his coaching role as well: the 1958 *Tamarack* refers to “**Burrill Exley’s cross-country team**” taking honors, and the 1957 *Tamarack* mentions track activity under Coach Exley.

One charming extra: a 2025 *Spokesman-Review* “This day in history” item reached back to 1925 and described 27-month-old **Burrill Dean Exley** as a Spokane Valley “mental wizard” who knew the alphabet at 17 months and could spell more than a dozen words — a delightful foreshadowing for a future math teacher.



Mr. Burrill Exley stumps his new Math Seminar class with a factoring problem.

From the **1968 Tamarack** with Mr. Exley at the chalk board, age 45.

Who was a radio operator and
gunner on B-17s in WWII, with
35 bombing missions over
Central Europe?

Faculty Helps Students Maintain Responsibilities

1968 Tamarack

Age 52

Wondering if he should let his
class do an experiment.

Wondering if he should risk letting his third period physics class do another experiment, is Mr. Orval Theisen.



1955 Tamarack

Age 39



1956 Tamarack

Age 40



1958 Tamarack

Age 42

1960 Tamarack

Age 44

Demonstrating
centrifugal
force with a
Hula Hoop.





1976
Tamarack

Age 60

The 1958 *Tamarack* lists “**Orval Theisen, physics**” in the science faculty, alongside Walter Spangenburg in biology and Donald Bonamy in biology. The 1959 *Tamarack* likewise lists “**Orval Theisen, physics**” in the science department. He remains visible in later *Tamarack* records: 1964 includes a caption referring to “**Orval Theisen, physics teacher,**” 1965 indexes him in the North Central yearbook, 1968 lists him among faculty, and 1976 indexes “**Theisen, Orval**” on page 30.

One nice professional detail: **Orval P. Theisen** published a letter titled “**Help Wanted!**” in *The Physics Teacher*, Volume 10, Issue 6, September 1972, page 301. That is a useful detail for your slide because it shows him not just as a local teacher, but as someone engaged with the national physics-teaching community.

I found a reasonably strong biographical outline for **Orval N. P. Theisen**, though I did **not** find a full newspaper obituary in open access.

Orval N. P. Theisen was born **January 14, 1916**, in **Erwin, Kingsbury County, South Dakota**, and died **August 7, 2007**, in **Spokane, Washington**, at age 91. FamilySearch gives his full indexed life span as **1916–2007**.

Your earlier NC Teachers notes summarize him as a longtime **physics and science teacher at North Central High School**, born in South Dakota, deceased in Spokane in August 2007, and associated with both physics teaching and *The Physics Teacher* journal.

Before his teaching career, he served in the U.S. military during World War II. The notes identify his service as **January 1943 to October 1945**, including Army Air Corps / Air Force service as a **radio operator and gunner on B-17s**, with **35 bombing missions over central Europe**. He married **Anna Aileene Cantlon** in Spokane on **January 5, 1946**.

Explosion in the Physics Lab

Who started at NC in 1956,
before any of us were born,
and was theoretical?



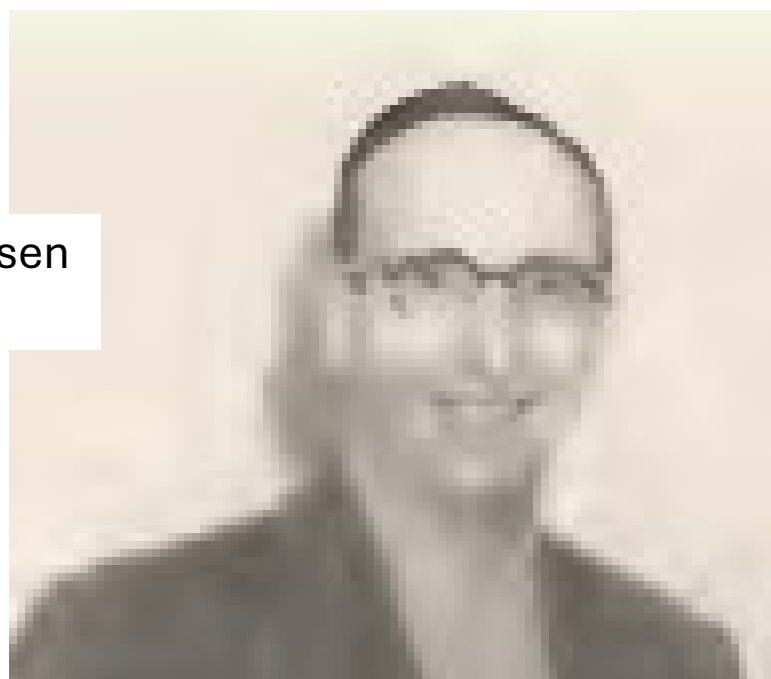
Mr. Nye
Algebra



Mr. Exley
Geometry



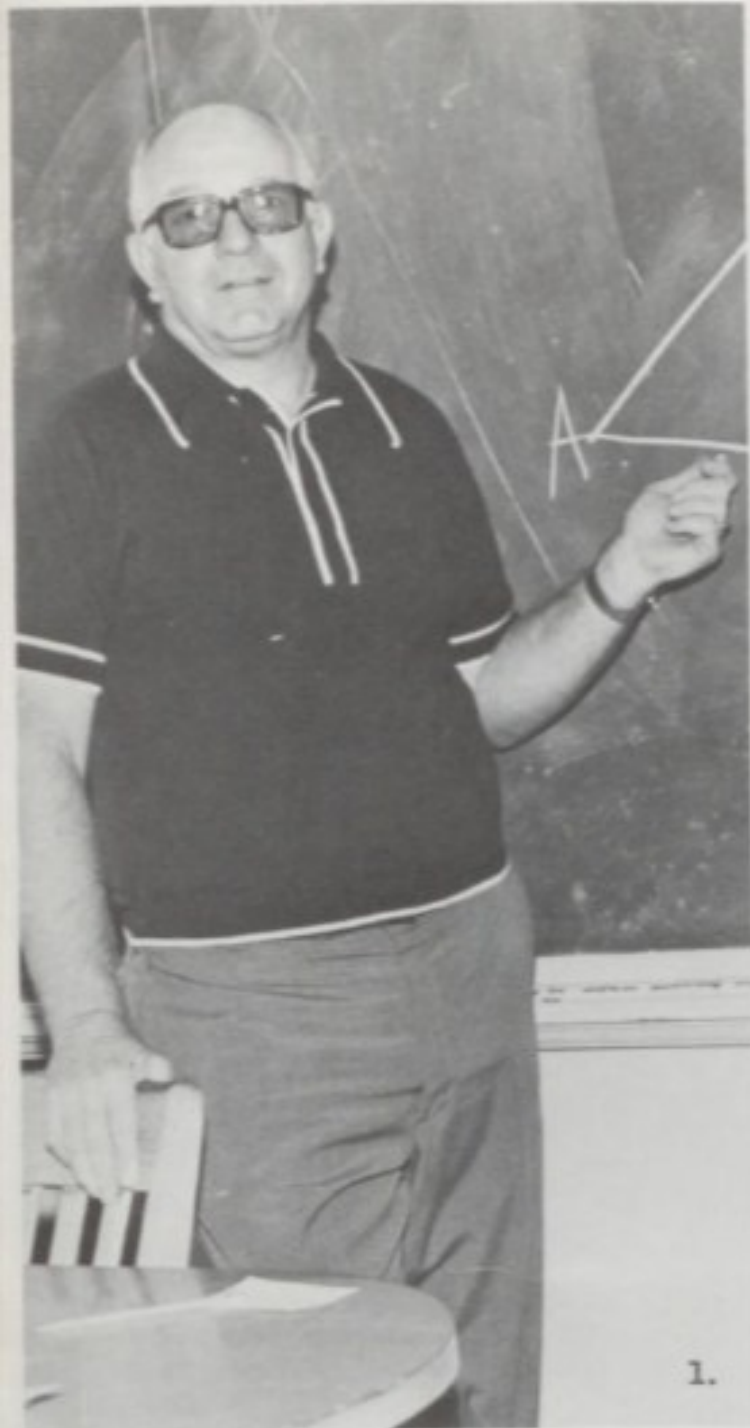
Mr. Theisen
Physics



Mr. Simonson
Biology



It's the 1956 Tamarack, and we're down to just 4 semi-finalists to see who, before we were all born, was the first of our teachers to start teaching at NC – all in the Math/Science Old Boy's Club!



I found a good **North Central yearbook trail**, but **not a reliable public obituary** for this older NC mathematics teacher in this pass. There are newer Spokane Public Schools records for a different/current **William Nye**, so I would keep the biographical claims conservative.

William Nye appears in the North Central *Tamarack* by **1956**, where the OCR places him in the mathematics faculty group: “Standing: Robert F. Barnard, algebra: William Nye...” By **1958**, he is clearly listed as “**William Nye, algebra**” in the mathematics department, alongside P. H. Nygaard, Mack Saunders, Robert Barnard, Dorothy Congdon, and Burrill Exley.

In the early 1960s he is listed with **general mathematics**. The 1961 *Tamarack* page text identifies him in the faculty group as “**William Nye, general mathematics.**” The 1963 yearbook also places him in the math department context, with a nearby caption involving Burrill Exley explaining an algebra equation.

He also appears to have coached or supervised **tennis**. The 1969 *Tamarack* says North Central’s tennis team was “**led by Mr. William Nye.**” The 1970 *Tamarack* similarly reports that the tennis team, under **William Nye**, ended in a tie for third place.

The 1975 *Tamarack* lists **William Nye** in the faculty material near Gene Rostvold, Burrill Exley, Gilbert Baker, and others.



1956 Tamarack Age >30?



1957 Tamarack Age >31?

Assuming he was 30 in his first year at NC in 1956, that would make him a centarian if with us.